Geography / Middle / secondary

Follow water through the water cycle

Water moves between stores through processes such as evaporation, condensation, precipitation, runoff and infiltration.

Core ideas

1. Evaporation changes liquid water into water vapour. Transpiration releases water vapour from plants.

2. Condensation changes water vapour into liquid droplets when suitable cooling occurs.

3. Water can flow over the ground as runoff or enter the ground through infiltration.

Worked example

Rain falls on a hillside. Some water flows over the surface to a stream, while some infiltrates the soil. Later, evaporation transfers some liquid water back into the atmosphere.

Try it yourself

1. Name the process that changes water vapour into liquid droplets.

2. What is infiltration?

3. Does all rainfall immediately become river water?

Check your answers

1. Condensation

2. Water entering the ground.

3. No. Water can enter several stores or pathways, including soil, surface flow and evaporation.